

Sharing memes to stay in touch: on new modes of digitally mediated social connection

Andreas Schellewald
Goldsmiths, University of London

Research context

- Personalisation as a dominant **media logic** (Kant, 2020) and **principle of social organization** (Lury and Day, 2019).
- TikTok exemplifies shift of **content-centricity** (Kaye et al. 2022) and **algorithm-user interaction** over user-user (Su 2023) or creator-follower relationships (Abidin 2021).
- Research focussed on **notion of self**, e.g., technology of self (Karakayali et al. 2017), algorithmized self (Bhandari and Bimo 2022), fragmentation of self (Lee et al. 2023).
- Concerns about **diminishing social qualities** (Gerbaudo 2024), echoing arguments on “lesser quality” of mediated sociality (Turkle 2011) and “phatic media culture” (Miller 2015).



Economist 2024



Has the reign of social media ended?

Le Monde 2024



Axios 2021

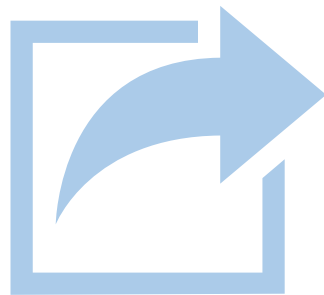
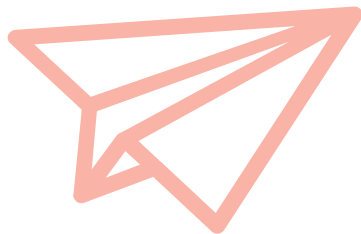
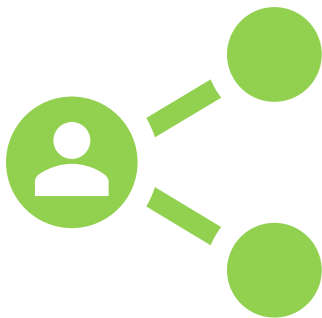


Mignano 2022

Research context

Media are not “social” by design but through their social use (Madianou and Miller 2012):

- Using media to **enrich** existing relationships and social practices (Baym, 2010).
- Media technologies as **catalysts** for group interactions (Prior, 2014).
- **Sensing** the presence of distant others through shared digital traces (Madianou, 2016).
- Creating **contextual awareness** via ephemeral video chats (Bayer et al., 2016).
- Algorithmic recommendations as **socio-cultural currency** in interaction (Siles, 2023).
- Sharing memes to **affirm close relationships** in online chats (McLean et al., 2023).



Research method



Digital Fieldwork

- Digital ethnography of TikTok, “For You” page.
- 6 months starting in early 2020.
- Daily routine of scrolling through the app for 30 to 60 mins.
- Content journal to explore new “sides” of TikTok via training algorithm and search.



Ethnography of TikTok Consumption

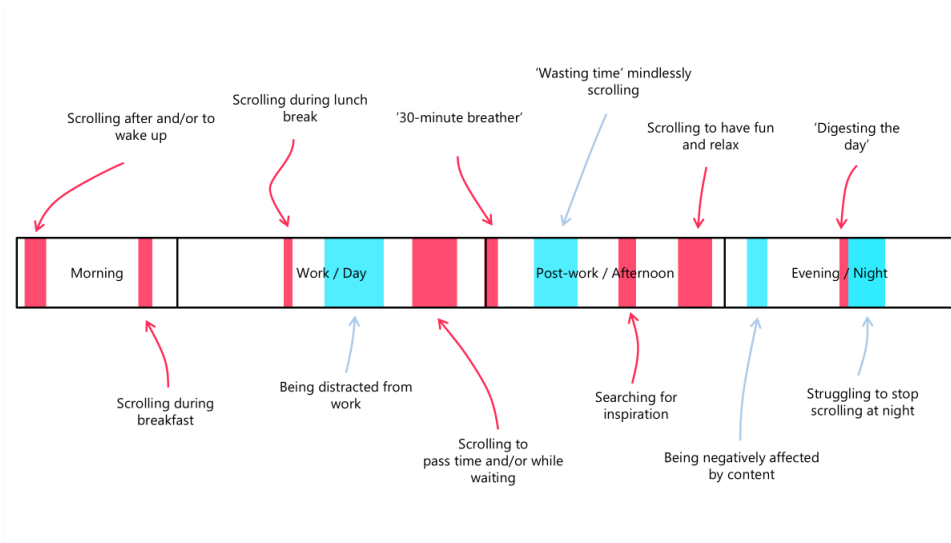
- Ethnographic study with 30 UK-based young adult TikTok users.
- 12 months starting in Summer 2020.
- Main data: semi-structured interviews at 3-month intervals.
- Additional: participant observations; media mapping; informal conversation.



Digital Fieldwork

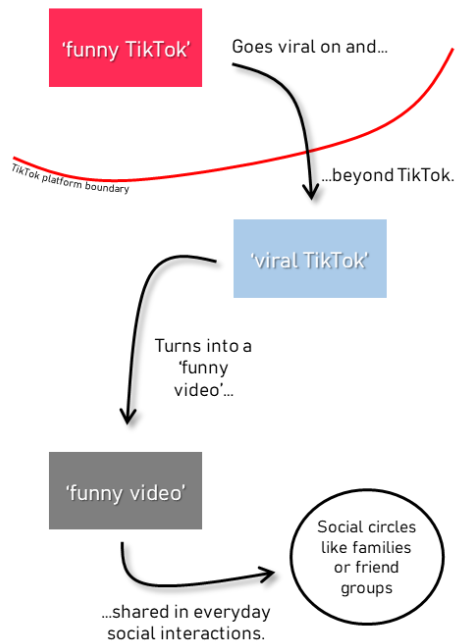
- Digital ethnography of Instagram Reels.
- 14 months starting in late 2023.
- Focussed engagement with “share this” genre.
- Collecting 839 videos of the genre through trained Instagram algorithm.
- Thematic analysis (together with Yiting Wang, U of Hawaii).

Sharing as an integral element of scrolling: apps like TikTok often fill the experientially empty spaces of daily schedules, at times to actively seek distraction and escape. Nonetheless, pathways back into social networks open up from that escapist practice.

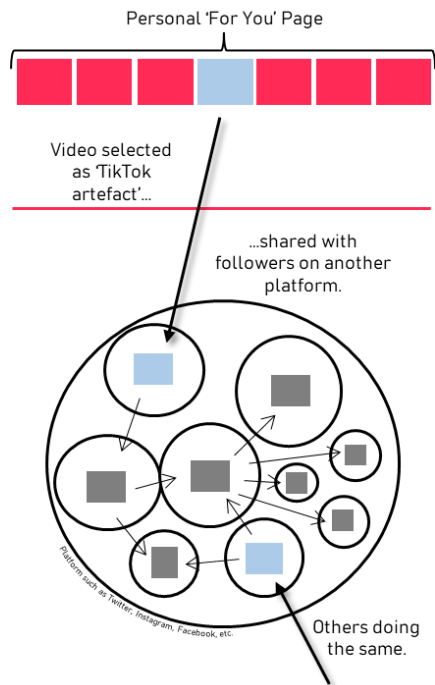


"I mean, it definitely has been an hour before [laughs] but it's normally twenty minutes or something, I think ... it might be like twenty minutes to half an hour, and then I'll send a few videos to my friends as well, like, you know ... I'll see one and think 'oh, that friend will find that funny' or 'this group of friends would find it funny'".
(Manu)

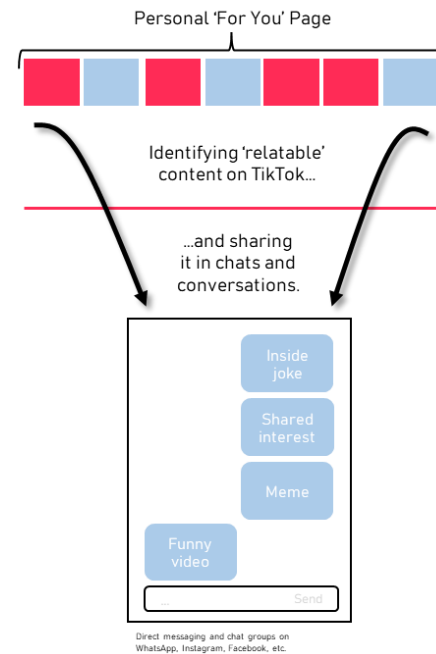
Indirect personal to social



Direct personal to public



Direct personal to interpersonal



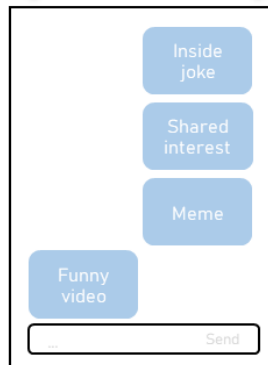
Direct personal to interpersonal

Personal 'For You' Page



Identifying 'relatable'
content on TikTok...

...and sharing
it in chats and
conversations.



Direct messaging and chat groups on
WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, etc.

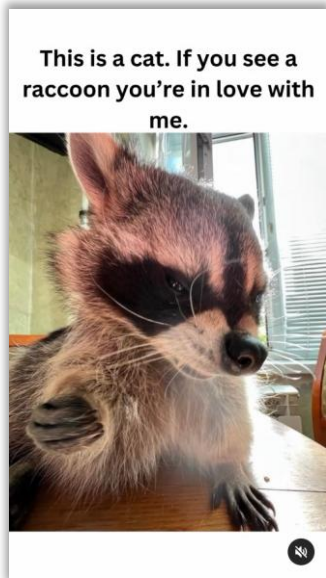
"I definitely share videos . . . when I share them with my friends, I definitely think it is stuff that relates to either them or both of us. Me and my friends, we send each other lots of Anime TikToks or London TikToks. Just because that's what we relate to."
(Isobel)

"I have two friends who also use TikTok, and our common interests are One Direction and Harry Styles, and that kind of music, and there's so many TikToks about them. Like, inside jokes in the fandom that would come up and I'd find that hilarious and send that to them, and they'd send me some"
(Velta)

"I share videos with my sister the most because she just enjoys them but doesn't really use TikTok. She's a bit older. I send her any TikTok that ... usually stuff related to our childhood, something that's funny, something that she mentioned or said yesterday, and I will be like "Oh, this TikTok literally speaks on that."
(Joyce)

Instagram sharing vernacular: videos that are designed to reaffirm the quality and closeness of a social bond. For example, along semantics of romantic affection, appreciation, longing, or light-hearted obligation and indebtedness.

Affection



Appreciation



Longing



Indebtedness



Instagram sharing vernacular: videos that are resources for playful and humorous interaction, allowing to reaffirm the positionality of the other as equal. For example, by sending content that is meant to tease the receiver.

Annoyance



Identification



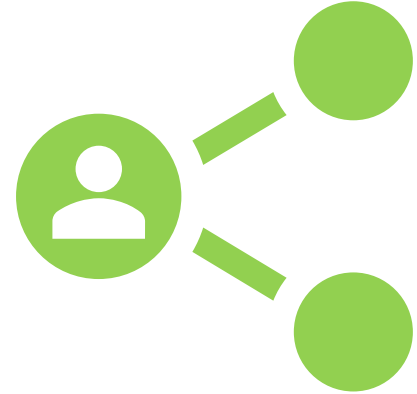
Funny



Elements of sociability on personalised media platforms

Material Element - Atmospheres of sociability

- Platforms provide cues (content) and opportunities (features) for interaction (social networks).
- Short content is easily convertible as a resource, it is flexibly integrated into relations without dominating the interaction.
- Mobility of medium allows for physical co-consumption (at home and elsewhere).
- Algorithmic media literacy and ability to act on cues become crucial skills.



Elements of sociability on personalised media platforms

Social Element - Playful social interaction

- Communication serves a self-fulfilling purpose of interaction (phatic / aesthetic function).
- Form and content of videos shared are used to affectively charge relationships (affection, longing, appreciation, tease).
- Social orderedness of interaction as equals, rules of what can be said / shared.
- Meaning emerges through the orderedness of interaction itself, it is in the play of the social that meaning is enacted.



Elements of sociability on personalised media platforms

Temporal Element - Paratexts to biographies

- Part of the continuous, biographic dialogue that defines the self through relationship with others.
- Affective paratext: continuous presence of distant others that are kept in mind / touch with through private, mobile media.
- Symbolic paratext: content that connects to past and present content of the interpersonal biography (references to memories, discussions, shared interests that tie together).



Conclusions on the sociability of short-video sharing

- Drawing on Simmel (1910), the value of sociability lies in its form: **stylized, playful, and regulated intimacy**. Social meaning is constituted in the ordered interaction more so than content.
- Digitally mediated sharing remediates **symposic rituals**: performative, ritualized, autotelic gatherings that sustains social bonds and order (Pfeiffer 2023).
- “Traditional” social domains (e.g., **friends, family**) provide **the relational infrastructure** that makes personalized media socially and emotionally significant (Madianou and Miller 2012).
- **Chat rooms** and shared temporal rhythms give ephemeral content durable interpersonal meaning. They open **spaces for affective and discursive self-making**.
- Content sharing function as **social catalyst** (McLean 2023) and **cultural capital**, demonstrating one's fluency in navigating digital sociality (Siles 2023).
- **Commodification** of the “stuff” around which emotional intimacies are expressed – remediating dynamics from cases like Hallmark and greeting card industry in US (West 2008).

Thanks!

Andreas Schellewald
Goldsmiths, University of London
asche006@gold.ac.uk